

were thrown away too cheaply in piecemeal frontal assaults. Bragg nonetheless emerged from the battle with his reputation intact.

One man who had admired him since they served together in the War with Mexico was President Jefferson Davis. The president correctly judged that Bragg's disciplinarian approach would allow him to toughen up and train volunteers into an effective fighting force. But by giving him the senior command in the Western Theater, Davis failed to take into account what other qualities might be needed in such a role.



Badge of status

During the Civil War swords were worn by officers as symbols of rank. Braxton Bragg's sword and scabbard is now in the Confederate Memorial Hall in New Orleans.

Leadership failings

Two major faults emerged as Bragg conducted operations in the bold invasion of Kentucky and the ensuing fighting in Tennessee. One was a loss of nerve that repeatedly led him to withdraw at precisely the moment when those around him felt he should stand firm or vigorously advance. The other fault was a chronic inability to collaborate with other generals or to establish any relationship of trust or mutual respect with his subordinates.

Bragg's bad temper and readiness to blame others contributed to a near breakdown in command that occurred in 1863 after the Battle of Stones River. He argued with his corps and divisional generals while they campaigned to have him removed. Sometimes his anger was justified—his contempt for the military abilities of Lieutenant General Leonidas Polk, for example. The politically well-connected Polk's resistance to his orders was clearly insubordinate. But Bragg cannot escape his share of the responsibility for a